Often still called selective mutism, which is unfortunate — nothing about it is selected. Whether this belongs under the neurodivergent umbrella is genuinely debated. Many people who have it identify as neurodivergent; some prefer not to. Both are reasonable, and nobody gets to decide it for you.

In plain words

Situational mutism is an inability to speak in certain settings despite speaking freely in others. It's an anxiety-based freeze response, not shyness, refusal or defiance. It usually begins in childhood and can persist into adult life. Many autistic people also lose speech temporarily during overload, which is related but distinct.

What it can feel like from the inside

- Wanting to answer, knowing the answer, and no sound coming out at all.
- Your throat physically closing rather than choosing silence.
- Speaking freely at home and being mute at the school gate.
- Adults treating your silence as rudeness or stubbornness.
- The pressure to speak making it categorically worse.

What people often get wrong

THE ASSUMPTION	WHAT'S ACTUALLY GOING ON
"They're just shy."	Shy people speak eventually. This is a freeze response with a physical component.
"They're being difficult."	Nobody chooses this. It's frightening and isolating for the person in it.
"Make them answer."	Pressure is the single most reliable way to make it worse.
"They can talk at home, so they can here."	That's the definition, not a contradiction.
"They'll grow out of it."	Some do; many need support. Waiting alone isn't a plan.

What often comes with it

NOT COMPENSATION PRIZES — GENUINE, USEFUL THINGS

Exceptional listening and observation.

Rich inner life and often strong writing.

Deep loyalty to the people they can speak with.

Sensitivity to atmosphere and other people's discomfort.

Considerable courage every time they try.

What actually helps

- ☐ Never insist on a verbal answer
- ☐ Talk alongside them without requiring replies
- ☐ Reduce audience size
- ☐ Accept writing, typing, nodding, pointing
- ☐ Don't announce or praise when they do speak
- ☐ Give questions in advance

If someone tells you this is them

HELPFUL

"Nod if that's right."

"Write it down if you'd rather."

"No rush."

LESS HELPFUL

"Cat got your tongue?"

"She spoke! Everyone, listen!"

"Just say it."

Not selected, not shyness, not rudeness. A freeze that needs patience, not pressure.

A friendly explainer written for the community — not a diagnostic tool and not medical advice. If you want an assessment, your GP is the place to start. Nobody experiences this identically, so take what fits and leave the rest.

Free to share — print it, forward it, hand it to anyone who needs it. More free guides, one per neurotype, at froglogic.co.uk